BOOKS ▼

Maker and Masterpiece

Vinod Kaul pieces together the life and untimely death of filmmaker Awtar Kaul, whose lone feature film remains a landmark of Indian New Wave cinema

Awtar Kaul made just one feature film, *27 Down*. On July 20, 1974, it was announced that the film had won National Awards for Best Hindi Feature Film and Best Black & White Cinematography. The family began to celebrate at home. None of them knew that at that very hour, Awtar had drowned in the sea at Chowpatty. Celebration turned to mourning.

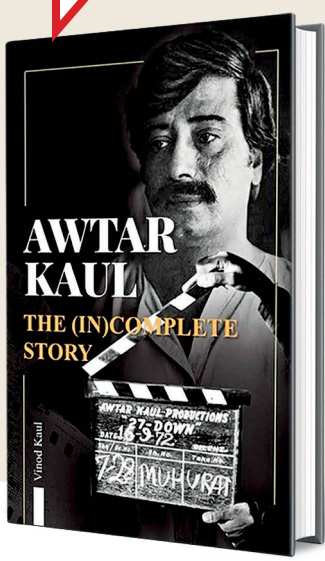
27 Down, based on Ramesh Bakshi's novel *Atharah Sooraj Ke Paudhe*, is considered a masterpiece of Indian New Wave cinema, yet it has never received the attention it deserves. *Awtar Kaul: The (In)complete Story*, by his nephew Vinod Kaul, seeks to correct that neglect. The author spent three years gathering material for the book from draft and working screenplays to the film's promotional poster, family photographs and memories of Awtar's collaborators.

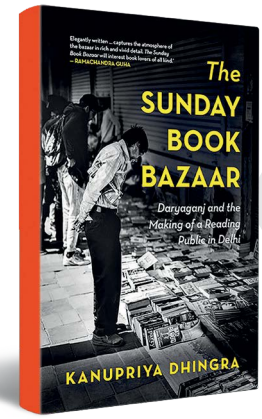
The book is strongest when it turns to intimate details like the recollections of actors M.K. Raina and Rakhee, stories from behind the scenes, and Awtar's annotations in the margins of the novel. However, the book is not without flaws. It brings together essays by several writers and some of the same moments keep returning: the award, the untimely death and the screening on his 50th death anniversary. A firmer editorial hand could have trimmed this repetition.

Two pieces, 'Anne: Remaining in the Shadows' and 'July 20, 1974', are particularly moving, heavy with tender memory. As we read on, we glimpse many shades of Awtar, yet much remains in shadow. The author admits that even the family has no answers to many questions. For anyone trying to understand Awtar Kaul and *27 Down*, this book may prove to be an important archive. ■

—Anjum Sharma

AWTAR KAUL:
The (In)complete Story
By Vinod Kaul
PUBLICATIONS DIVISION
₹365; 258 pages





THE SUNDAY BOOK BAZAAR
Daryaganj and the Making of a Reading Public in Delhi
By Kanupriya Dhingra
SPEAKING TIGER BOOKS
₹599; 336 pages

BOOKS ▼

A MARKET OF STORIES

KANUPRIYA DHINGRA has written a comprehensive account of the Daryaganj Sunday book bazaar's cultural influence and legacy

Roughly a third of the books I own come from the Sunday book market at Daryaganj. As a young and penniless journalist in the early 2010s, I quickly immersed myself in the rhythms of this weekly treasure trove. And while I had read scholarly essays on the place, I had always wondered why an Indian academic hadn't yet written a comprehensive book on the place's cultural influence and legacy, combining journalistic, historiographic and sociological approaches. Kanupriya Dhingra's *The Sunday Book Bazaar* is that book.

DHINGRA BEGINS BY LAYING OUT THE HISTORY OF DARYAGANJ ITSELF, A "ZONE OF TRANSITION"

Dhingra begins by laying out the history of Daryaganj itself, a "zone of transition, a buffer between the compact density of Shajahanabad and the imperial expansiveness of New Delhi". These sections, drawing on Mughal and then colonial-era texts, are well-researched and give us a clear idea of the region's socio-economic trajectory across the last 200 years. But the book is even more impressive when it introduces us to its indefatigable crew of itinerant booksellers—people who've made a living doing this often for decades. On the gender question, too, Dhingra is terrific, delivering well-rounded portraits of the few women booksellers who operate in this male-dominated space.

In 2019, the market's legal troubles culminated in its relocation to the nearby Mahila Haat. What endures, though, is its significance to the lives of Delhi's reading public. ■

—Aditya Mani Jha